



Acts 5:1-11 “The Filling of The Heart (Pt. 2)”

Intro:

Last week we observed five characteristics of a heart filled with the Holy Spirit. This week we will observe five characteristics of a heart filled by Satan. Before we do so, however, it is important to understand that what we are seeing in this passage is not demonic possession, but satanic temptation and influence (similar to Matthew 16:21–23). We see this clearly because Peter says in verse 4, **“Why is it that you have contrived this deed in your heart?”** Satan did not commit the sin for Ananias and Sapphira. All he could do was tempt and influence them, and they willingly allowed him to fill their hearts. This is important because believers, too, can allow their hearts to be influenced by Satan. Therefore, as we study this passage, we must honestly examine ourselves to make sure none of these characteristics begin taking root in our own hearts.

ACTS 5:1-11 ESV: “But a man named *Ananias*, with his wife *Sapphira*, sold a piece of property, and **with his wife’s knowledge he kept back for himself some of the proceeds and brought only a part of it and laid it at the apostles’ feet.** But Peter said, “Ananias, **why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit** and to **keep back for yourself** part of the proceeds of the land? While it remained unsold, *did it not remain your own?* And after it was sold, *was it not at your disposal?* **Why is it that you have contrived this deed in your heart? You have not lied to man but to God.**” *When Ananias heard these words, he fell down and breathed his last.* And great fear came upon all who heard of it. The young men rose and wrapped him up and carried him out and buried him. After an interval of about three hours his wife came in, *not knowing what had happened.* And Peter said to her, **“Tell me whether you sold the land for so much.”** And she said, “Yes, for so much.” But Peter said to her, **“How is it that you have agreed together to test the Spirit of the Lord? Behold, the feet of those who have buried your husband are at the door, and they will carry you out.”** *Immediately she fell down at his feet and breathed her last.* When the young men came in they found her dead, and they carried her out and buried her beside her husband. **And great fear came upon the whole church and upon all who heard of these things.”**

1. **Envy**

As we study Scripture verse by verse, it is important that we never isolate a passage from its context. Immediately before introducing Ananias and Sapphira, Luke presents Barnabas and his remarkable Spirit-led generosity. Barnabas did not simply give a portion of the proceeds from the land he sold—he willingly gave the entire amount. This seems to provide an important clue to Ananias and Sapphira's motives. It is very possible that after seeing Barnabas' generosity, along with the respect and admiration it received, they desired that same recognition for themselves without making the same sacrifice. Rather than rejoicing in God's work through Barnabas, they appear to have desired his reputation. A heart influenced by Satan is easily poisoned by envy toward the blessings, recognition, or usefulness of other believers instead of rejoicing in what God is doing through them.

2. **Pride**

Where there is envy, pride is never far behind because envy is born out of pride. We envy others because we desire for ourselves what God has given to someone else. Pride cannot tolerate others being recognized, honored, or admired because it constantly wants to be the center of attention.

Proverbs 16:18 reminds us, **“Pride comes before destruction, and an arrogant spirit before a fall.”**

3. **Conspiracy** (V.2,9)

A conspiracy is a secret agreement between two or more people to accomplish something sinful or deceptive. That is exactly what we see in this passage. Ironically, this almost mirrors the unity we observed in chapter 4. The believers were united by the Holy Spirit in sacrificial love. Ananias and Sapphira were united by their sinful desires in deception. One was a selfless unity centered on Christ; the other was a selfish unity centered on themselves. How tragic that instead of this husband and wife encouraging one another toward faithfulness, they encouraged one another toward sin. Rather than sharpening one another in righteousness, they strengthened one another in rebellion against God.

4. **Self Interest** (V.3)

Rather than giving out of sacrificial love, everything they did was motivated by self-interest. Their concern was not primarily for God's glory or the needs of others, but for their own reputation. They secretly kept back part of the proceeds while publicly pretending they had given everything. This is the exact opposite of the Spirit-filled love we observed in chapter 4. Love sacrifices itself for others. Self-interest sacrifices others for itself.

5. **Deception** (V.4)

The issue was not that they didn't give the full amount, as clearly seen in verse 4. The problem was the deception. In attempting to lie to the apostles the one there were really lying to was God. **They were more worried about appearing Godly than actually being Godly.** And in this they belittle God and disregarded Him. In their case their deception was an attempt to cover up their pride and greed, but a life of deception always comes with sin whatever the type. A heart being filled and influenced by Satan is one that lives in the shadows, one that instead of living in transparency attempts to be perceived as something it's not. *Instead of our greatest fear being sin itself, our greatest fear becomes that our sin might be exposed.* (Consider 1 John 1:5-10, 2:21)

Conclusion:

It is interesting that in chapter 4 Satan attempted to stop the progress of the church through persecution from those outside the church. In chapter 5, however, he changes his strategy. Rather than attacking from the outside, he begins attacking from within by influencing the hearts of those inside the church. History has repeatedly shown that this is often one of his most effective tactics. If we are honest with ourselves, every one of us is capable of becoming an Ananias or a Sapphira if we allow our hearts to drift from Christ. Yet this passage is both comforting and sobering. It comforts us because Christ faithfully protects and purifies His church. But it should also leave us with a holy fear as we see God's unwavering commitment to the holiness of His bride. Perhaps the most astonishing part of this account is not that God judged Ananias and Sapphira, but that He has not judged us in the same way. Every one of us deserves His righteous judgment, yet God has been patient with us, giving us opportunity after opportunity to repent and turn to Him. His patience, however, will not last forever. The day of the Lord will come. Therefore, let us repent while His gracious invitation still stands. (Consider Isaiah 55:6-7, Joel 2:12-13)

- “The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, **but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance.** *But the day of the Lord will come* like a thief, and then the heavens will pass away with a roar, and the heavenly bodies will be burned up and dissolved, and the earth and the works that are done on it will be exposed.” 2 Peter 3:9-10 ESV

Main Idea:

A heart filled by Satan produces envy, pride, conspiracy, self-interest, and deception from the inside out. Therefore, let us daily walk with the Lord through His Word and submit ourselves to the Holy Spirit, allowing Him to continually search, purify, and fill our hearts so that these sinful characteristics are put to death and Christ is increasingly formed in us.

Memory Verse:

“But Peter said, “Ananias, why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit and to keep back for yourself part of the proceeds of the land?”

Acts 5:3 ESV

